

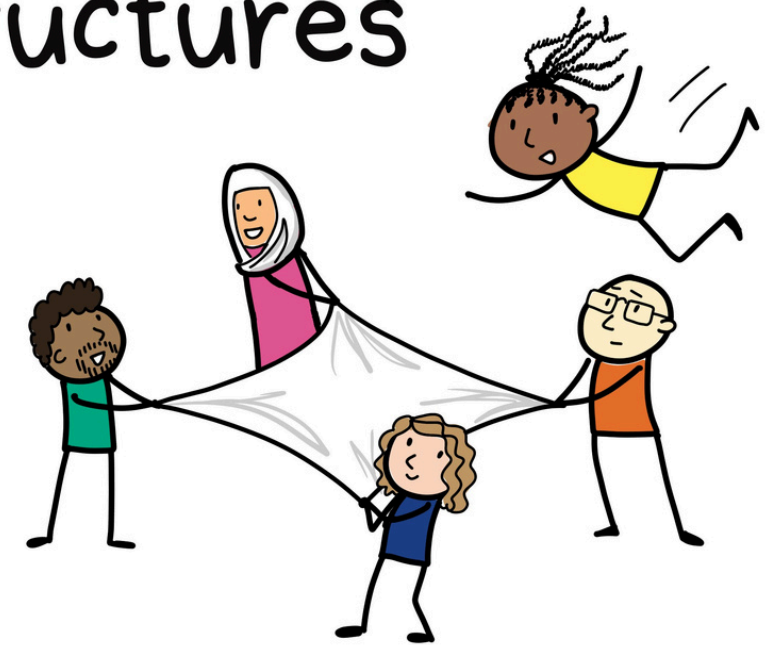
The 10 principles of Liberating Structures



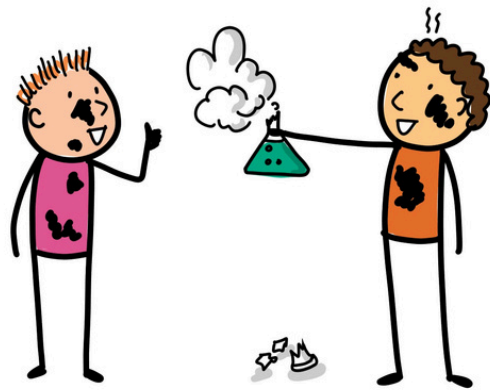
1 Include and unleash everyone



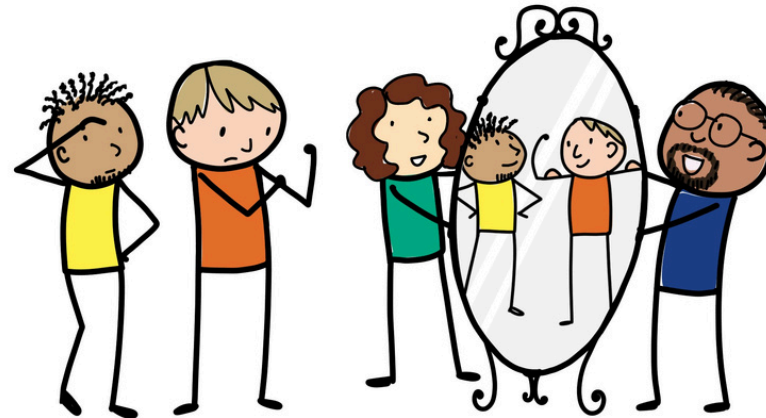
2 Practice deep respect
for people and local solutions



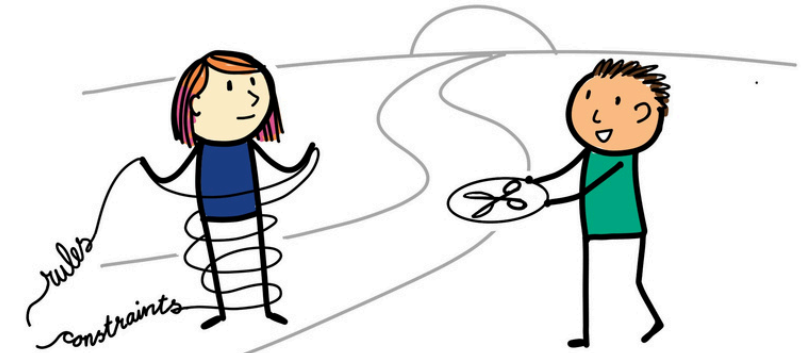
3 Build trust as you go



4 Learn by failing forward



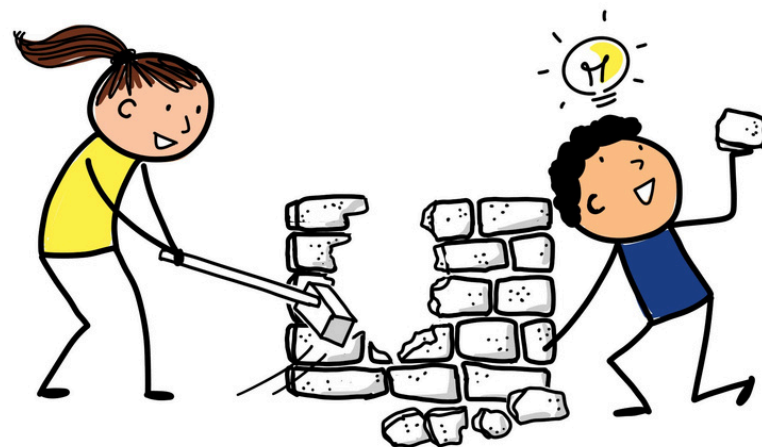
5 Practice self-discovery
within a group



6 Amplify freedom AND responsibility



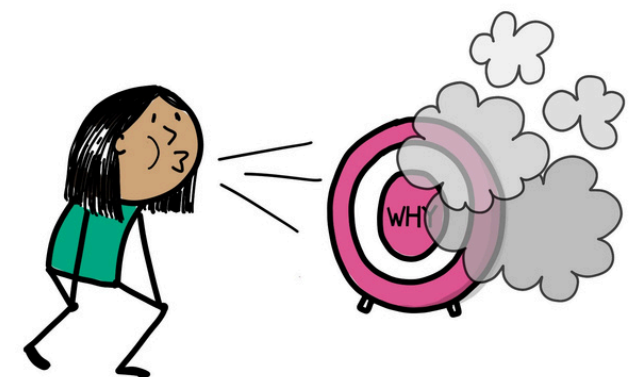
7 Emphasize possibilities:
believe before you see



8 Invite creative destruction
to enable innovation



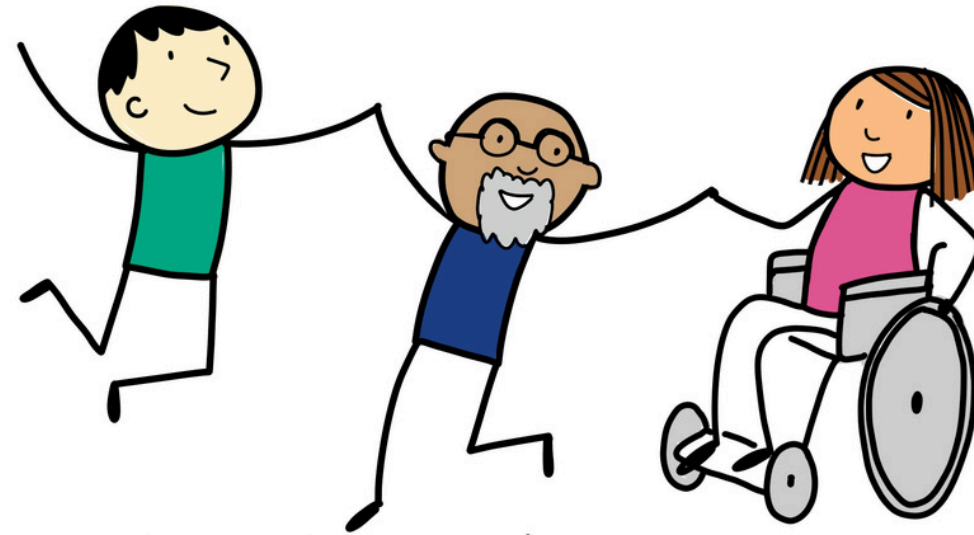
9 Engage in
seriously-playful curiosity



10 Never start
without clear purpose

1. Include and Unleash Everyone

Must Do (Start & Amplify)



Must Not Do (Stop & Reduce)

Invite everyone touched by a challenge to share possible solutions or invent new approaches together.

Actively reach across levels, beyond the usual suspects.

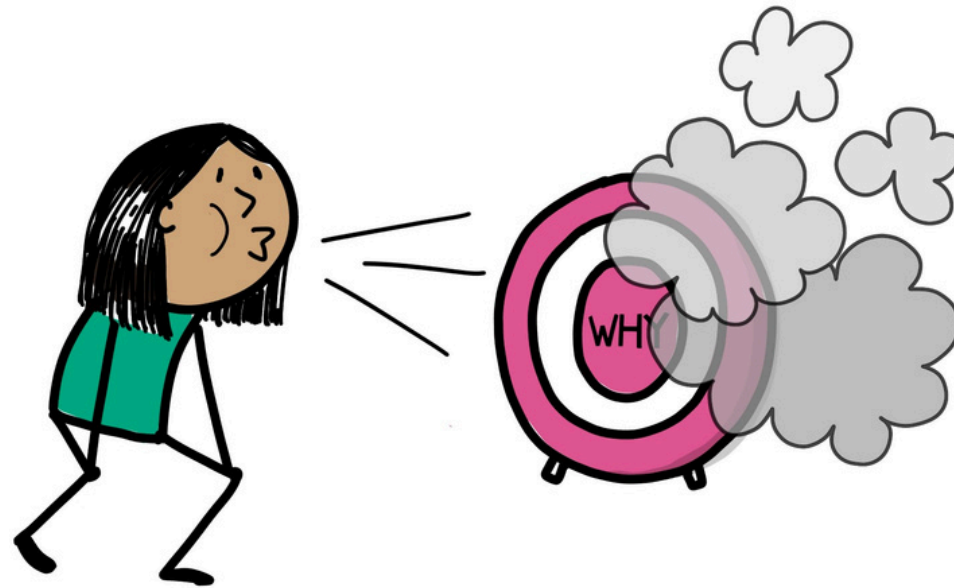
Appoint a few to design an “elegant solution” and then tell all others to implement it after the fact.

Confront resistance with hours of PPT presentations. Force buy-in. Separate deciders from doers.



2. Never Start Without A Clear Purpose

Must Do
(Start & Amplify)



Must Not Do
(Stop & Reduce)

Dig deep for what is important and meaningful to you and to others.

Take time to include everyone in crafting an unambiguous statement of the deepest need for your work.

Maintain ambiguity by using jargon.

Substitute a safe short-term goal or means-to-an-end for a bold reason to exist or deep need.

Impose your purpose on others.



3. Practice Deep Respect for People and Local Solutions

Must Do (Start & Amplify)

Engage people doing the work & familiar with the local context.

Trust and unleash their collective expertise and inventiveness to solve complex challenges.

Let go of the compulsion to control.



Must Not Do (Stop & Reduce)

Import best practices, drive buy-in, or assume people need more training.

Privilege experts and computer systems over local people and know-how.



4. Build Trust As You Go

Must Do (Start & Amplify)

Cultivate a trusting group climate where speaking the truth is valued and shared ownership is the goal.

Sift ideas & make decisions using input from everyone.

Practice “nothing about me without me.”

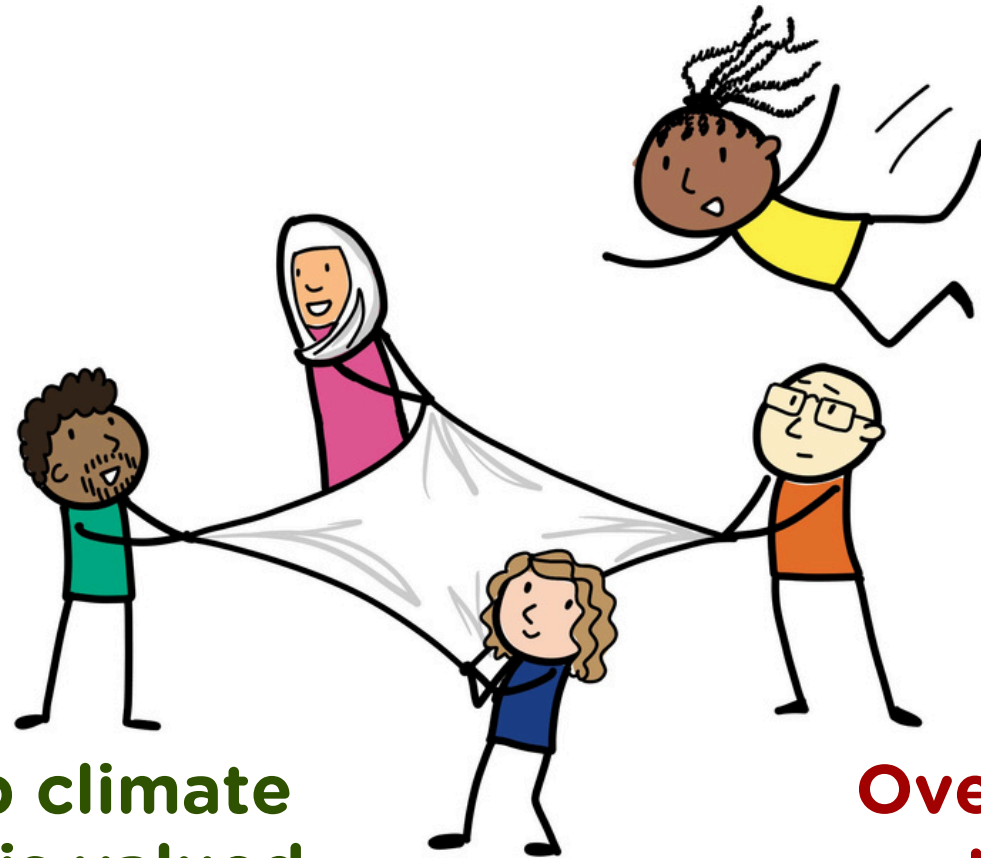
Be a leader and a follower.

Must Not Do (Stop & Reduce)

Over-help or over-control the work of others.

Praise and pretend to follow the ideas of colleagues.

Indirectly, respond to ideas from others with cynicism, ridicule, criticism, or punishment.



5. Learn by Failing Forward

Must Do
(Start & Amplify)

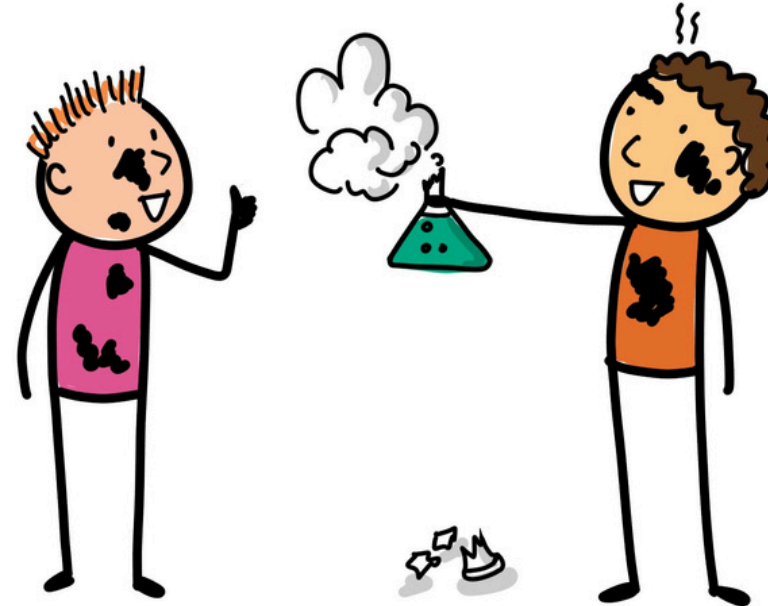
Debrief every step.

Make it safe to speak up.

Discover positive variation.

**Include and unleash clients
as you innovate.**

**Take small risks quickly,
reducing time between iterations.**



Must Not Do
(Stop & Reduce)

Focus on doing and deciding.

**Avoid difficult conversations
and gloss over failures.**

**Punish risk-takers when
unknowable surprises pop-up.**



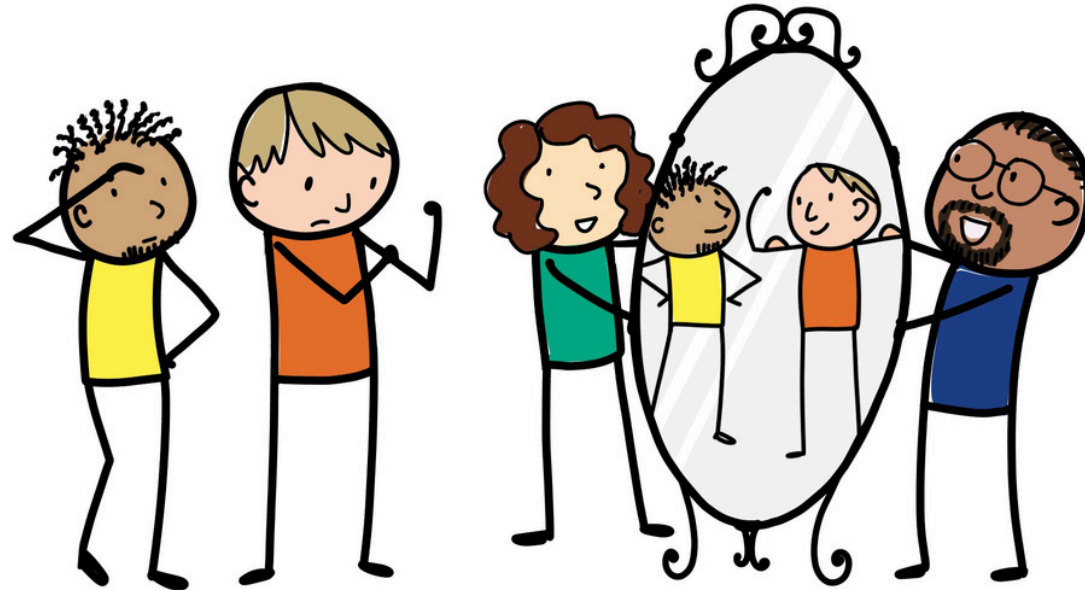
6. Practice Self-Discovery Within A Group

Must Do (Start & Amplify)

Engage groups to the maximum degree in discovering solutions on their own.

Increase diversity to spur creativity, broaden potential solutions and enrich peer-to-peer learning.

Encourage experiments on multiple tracks.



Must Not Do (Stop & Reduce)

Impose solutions from the top.

Let experts “educate” and tell people what to do.

Assume that people resist change no matter what.

Substitute laminated signs for conversation.

Exclude front line people from innovating.



7. Amplify Freedom AND Responsibility

Must Do

(Start & Amplify)

Specify minimum constraints and let go of over-control.

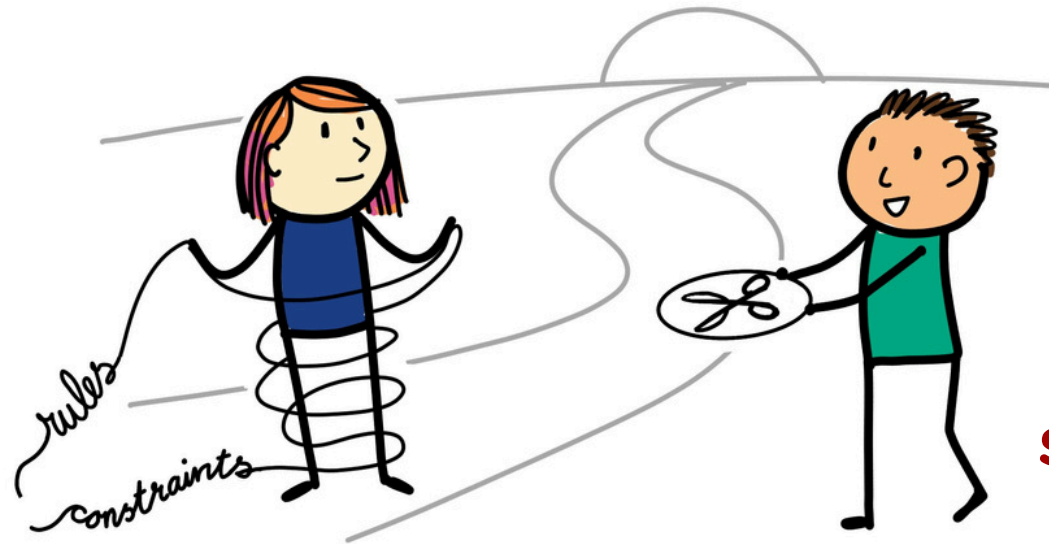
Use the power of invitation.

Privilege fast experiments over playing it safe.

Track progress rigorously and feed back results to all.

Invite the frontline to create local performance metrics.

Celebrate mistakes as sources of progress.



Must Not Do

(Stop & Reduce)

Unleash people without structure such as a clear purpose or minimum specifications.

Let rules and procedures stifle initiative.

Ignore the value of people understanding how their work affects one another.

Keep frontline staff in the dark about performance data.



8. Emphasize Possibilities: Believe Before You See

Must Do

(Start & Amplify)

Expose what is
working well.

Focus on what can be
accomplished now with
the imagination and
materials at hand.

Take the next steps that
lead to the edge of
creativity and renewal.



Must Not Do

(Stop & Reduce)

Focus on what's wrong.

Wait for all the barriers to
come down or ideal
conditions to emerge.

Work on changing the
whole system all at once.



9. Invite Creative Destruction To Enable Innovation

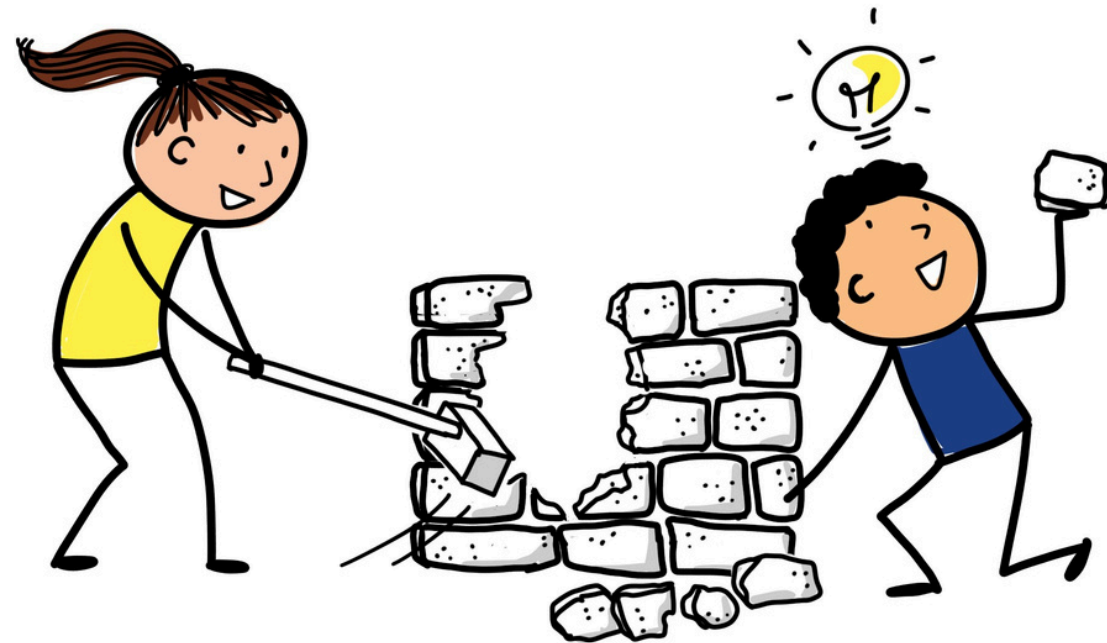
Must Do

(Start & Amplify)

Convene conversations about what is keeping people from working on the essence of their work.

Remove the barriers even when it feels like heresy.

Make it easy for people to deal with their fears



Must Not Do

(Stop & Reduce)

Avoid or delay stopping the behaviors, practices and policies that are revealed as barriers.

Assume obstacles don't matter or can't be removed.



10. Engage In Seriously-Playful Curiosity

Must Do (Start & Amplify)

Stir things up – with levity, paradoxical questions, and improv – to spark a deep exploration of current practices and latent innovations.

Make working together both demanding and inviting.



Must Not Do (Stop & Reduce)

Keep it simple by deciding in advance what the solutions should be.

Control all conversations.

Ask only closed yes or no questions.

Make working together feel like drudgery.

